

TRENCH WARFARE

THE BATTLE OF ARRAS

Caught in the stalemate of trench warfare, armies on the Western Front in World War I sought a fresh approach. In the Battle of Arras in April 1917, British and Commonwealth forces had initial success in infantry assaults on German lines, but fell short of the longed-for breakthrough.

British commanders at Arras were determined to avoid the disasters of the Somme offensive the previous year, when troops had plodded in lines toward machine-gun fire. Artillery and infantry planned to mount a skilful combined assault on the German positions, including the well-held Vimy Ridge. Before the operation, tunnels leading to the front were excavated to shelter the assembling troops. The longest of these tunnels was over a mile in length. Short trenches or “saps” stretched into the no-man’s-land between the trench lines to provide advanced jumping-off points for the assault. Artillery observers, meanwhile, plotted the positions of German heavy guns, using sophisticated sound-ranging techniques and by spotting their muzzle flashes when they fired. This enabled British gunners to deliver accurate counter-battery fire, suppressing the German artillery when the attack began. Infantry and artillery officers also worked on coordinating a “creeping barrage” — a moving screen of exploding shells in front of advancing Allied troops.

The offensive was preceded by a week-long bombardment of the German lines by more than 900 guns. This sacrificed any hope of surprise, but special fuses allowed shells to effectively break up the barbed wire in front of the German trenches — an essential preparation for the infantry advance. The attack was launched at 5:30am on Easter Monday, 9 April, with Canadian troops assigned to the sector in front of Vimy Ridge.

Soldiers moved forward, keeping some 46m (50 yards) behind the creeping artillery barrage. Other

guns subdued the German batteries and fired poison gas shells into their defences. Massed British machine-guns meanwhile fired over advancing troops and onto German trenches, while dozens of tanks lumbered forward in support of the infantry.

The first wave of attackers reached the German frontline trenches in most places, at which point a fierce close-quarters struggle ensued with grenades and bayonets. A second wave of troops then passed through the first to continue the advance. British troops overcame German machine-gun nests using flexible small-unit tactics: one half of a platoon gave covering fire as their comrades dashed forward to attack. By the end of the first day’s fighting, Vimy Ridge was in Canadian hands and other British troops had advanced about 5km (3 miles).

RETURN TO STALEMATE

On 11 April British General Edmund Allenby claimed that his army was “pursuing a defeated enemy”. Cavalry were sent forward in expectation of a breakthrough into open country, but this proved vastly overoptimistic. The artillery had performed impressively, but had also churned up the ground over which the advance had to proceed. While engineers prepared a path on which the British heavy guns could move forward, the Germans reinforced their defences. By 14 April, the advance had ground to a halt in the face of fresh German troops and uncut barbed wire. As was so often the case in World War I, doomed attempts to revive the offensive then went on for far too long, producing heavy casualties for little or no further gain.

